

Conflict is an undeniable staple of human interaction that shapes our connections to one another. How these situations resolve can completely alter the relationship between two people. Specifically, a transgressor's ability to apologize to a victim after an interpersonal offense. One of the most important variables in this area of study is intellectual humility, which describes an individual's ability to identify gaps in their own beliefs and admit to wrongdoing. An individual's level of intellectual humility can influence how likely, or unlikely, they are to apologize when they wrong another person (Ludwig et al. 2022). Another useful term when measuring conflict resolution interactions is preemptive forgiveness, which is the process of forgiving the transgressor before an apology is given (Struthers et al., 2008). Despite this, there is still very limited knowledge of what truly makes a high-quality apology. The predominant issue seems to be the application of post-transgressional response mediation. In other words, there needs to be a way to successfully improve the levels of intellectual humility and high-quality apologies on a general scale. If we can successfully increase these levels within our study, it may have significant applications. This study aims to answer the following three questions. First, does intellectual humility promote higher quality apologies? Second, does preemptive forgiveness change the response of the transgressor to provide a higher quality apology? And finally, does intellectual humility influence post-transgressional forgiveness positively?

Conflict can emerge from a multitude of situations. Specifically, we will be looking at conflict that stems from wrongdoing. This involves a transgressor invoking negative emotions within a victim through an action or offense that goes against the victims' beliefs. Apologies seek to resolve conflict by inducing forgiveness in the victim (Ludwig et al. 2022). They are not only beneficial to quickly resolving a conflict but can also create lasting effects that positively impact relationships (Koetke et al. 2024). Thus, it is important that we understand what type of behavior influences these apologies.

Intellectual humility is the perfect balance between confidence in your own beliefs and the openness to being wrong, and fluctuating between the two as a situation requires (Porter et al. 2022). Individuals with intellectual humility are more likely to relinquish their own pride in their beliefs and seek to understand (Ludwig et al. 2022). Psychologically targeting a transgressor can have significant implications, as affirmations can lead transgressors to be less defensive and have more comprehensive apologies (Schumann, 2014). Furthermore, Ludwig et al. (2022) found that

apology behavior was directly impacted by both intellectual and general humility. Clearly, there is sufficient reasoning to investigate the relationship between intellectual humility and high-quality apologies.

A victim's post-transgression response influences apology behavior because it changes the transgressor's emotional experience (Struthers et al., 2008). Struthers et al. (2008) conducted a study on undergraduate students with the goal of determining how preemptive forgiveness can increase distress in the transgressor, which may lead them to feel guilty. This feeling of guilt usually motivates a person to apologize. However, if the transgressor does not feel responsible for the offense, preemptive forgiveness can backfire and instead create feelings of shame. This shameful feeling can promote the transgressor to pull away, rather than apologize. This study specifically looks at the effect of the victim's response on the transgressor's apology behavior. Our second research question aims to determine whether there is a legitimate effect or not. So, these findings will be extremely useful to tie into the results of our own experiment.

Additionally, a paper published identifying the effects of post-transgression responses on apology (Joshua Robert Guilfoyle, 2015) looked at the relationship between post-transgressional response and preemptive forgiveness. Specifically, it looked not only on the transgressors' willingness to apologize, but their level of self-control and their level of social pain. These variables are also related to intellectual humility and can give us more insight into creates an effective apology as well as what prevents specific social effects lead someone not to seek reconciliation.

In the current study, we examined whether intellectual humility influences apology quality when a transgressor is pre-emptively forgiven or not. We invoked a higher level of intellectual humility in some participants, while others were put in a control condition. After they are primed, we have them read a story where they are the transgressors in a conflict. Participants are then either preemptively forgiven or not by the victim and choose how they would respond using a multiple-choice questionnaire. First, we hypothesized that participants assigned to the intellectual humility condition will have more effective apologies than the control group. Second, we hypothesized that participants assigned to the high forgiveness condition will have better apologies than those in the unforgiving condition. Finally, we hypothesized that the highest

quality apologies will emerge from participants assigned to both the high forgiveness and intellectual humility conditions.

References

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